

Analysis Report

Generational Communication Training for New Interns

Project: New Intern Onboarding Training
Company: NorthStar Rail
Training Topic: Communicating with Senior Managers and Leaders
ADDIE Phase: Analysis

1. Executive Summary

NorthStar Rail is preparing to launch a new onboarding training session for graduate interns. The purpose of this training is to help early-career professionals communicate more effectively with senior managers, leaders, and experienced employees across the organization.

New interns often enter the workplace with strong academic knowledge and technical potential, but many are still developing the communication skills needed in a corporate environment. Common challenges include asking unclear questions, writing overly casual messages, hesitating to speak in meetings, and feeling unsure about how to respond to feedback from senior employees.

This analysis recommends a practical, scenario-based communication workshop focused on helping interns communicate upward with clarity, confidence, professionalism, and respect. The training should be included as part of the intern onboarding program and supported with simple reinforcement tools after the session.

2. Business Context

NorthStar Rail is a large railway transportation company with corporate, operations, engineering, safety, and field teams across Canada. Each year, the company hires new graduates into internship and early-career programs.

Because interns often work with cross-functional teams and report to experienced managers, their ability to communicate clearly has a direct impact on onboarding speed, project efficiency, and team collaboration.

This training supports the company’s broader goals of:

Business Goal	Connection to Training
Faster intern onboarding	Interns learn how to ask better questions and clarify expectations earlier

Stronger manager-intern relationships	Interns communicate with confidence and professionalism
Improved project efficiency	Clearer updates and follow-ups reduce confusion
Better leadership visibility	Interns learn how to present ideas and questions appropriately
Stronger early-career talent	Interns feel more prepared to contribute and grow

A structured corporate training approach should begin with identifying performance gaps and aligning learning goals to business needs, rather than creating training simply to fill onboarding time.

3. Training Need

The training need is not simply to teach interns about “generational differences.” The deeper need is to help interns understand how communication expectations shift when they move from an academic or peer-based environment into a professional workplace.

Interns need practical tools to communicate with senior managers and leaders in ways that are clear, concise, respectful, and action-oriented.

Training Need Statement

New graduate interns at NorthStar Rail need a practical onboarding communication session that helps them adapt their communication style when interacting with senior managers, leaders, and experienced employees. The training should help interns build confidence, ask clear questions, communicate professionally, participate in meetings, and respond constructively to feedback.

4. Target Audience Analysis

Primary Audience

The primary learners are **new graduate interns** joining NorthStar Rail.

Category	Learner Description
Career stage	Entry-level, new graduates, 0–1 year of professional experience
Typical Work	Engineering, business, IT, operations, finance, HR, safety, project Hybrid offices, virtual meetings, project teams, and occasional field/site
Strengths	Motivated, educated, technology-comfortable, eager to contribute
Challenges	Limited workplace communication experience, low confidence with senior leaders

Emotional state	Excited but nervous; wants to make a good impression
Learning preference	Practical examples, clear models, realistic practice, quick feedback

Although the learners are young, they are still adult learners. Adult learning theory emphasizes practical, relevant, self-directed learning that connects clearly to real needs.

5. Current Performance vs. Desired Performance

Current Performance

Many interns currently rely on communication habits developed in school, part-time jobs, or peer environments. These habits do not always transfer smoothly into corporate communication with senior managers.

Current Behavior	Workplace Impact
Hesitates to speak up in meetings	Missed opportunities to clarify tasks or contribute ideas
Asks vague questions	Managers spend extra time identifying the real issue
Sends overly casual messages	Communication may appear unclear or unprofessional
Writes long, unfocused emails	Key requests or deadlines may be missed
Takes feedback personally	Slower improvement and reduced confidence
Avoids senior leaders	Less visibility and weaker relationship-building

Desired Performance

After training, interns should be able to communicate in a way that supports productivity, professionalism, and confidence.

Desired Behavior	Example
Ask clear, specific questions	"I reviewed the report and have one question about the safety metric on page 3."
Use concise updates	"The draft is complete. I need your input on two items before Friday."
Adjust tone by audience	Use a more structured tone with managers and leaders
Participate appropriately in meetings	Prepare one point, ask one question, and confirm next steps
Respond constructively to feedback	"Thank you. I'll revise the section and send an updated version tomorrow."
Escalate issues professionally	Share the issue, impact, options, and recommended next step

6. Performance Gap Analysis

The key performance gap is the difference between how interns naturally communicate as new graduates and how they are expected to communicate in a professional, leader-facing environment.

Gap Area	Current Gap	Desired Capability
Communication structure	Messages may be unclear or too long	Use purpose, context, request, and next step
Tone adaptation	May be too casual or too hesitant	Adjust tone based on audience and
Asking questions	Questions may be broad or	Ask specific, timely, well-prepared
Meeting participation	May stay silent or speak without structure	Contribute clearly and respectfully
Feedback response	May feel defensive or	Receive, clarify, and act on feedback
Confidence	May avoid senior employees	Communicate with professionalism and ownership

This gap requires skill practice, not just information delivery. Scenario-based learning is recommended because it allows employees to practice workplace decisions and communication behaviors in a safe environment.

7. Root Cause Analysis

The communication gap appears to come from several root causes:

Root Cause	Explanation
Limited professional	Interns may not have seen enough examples of strong workplace
Unclear expectations	They may not know what senior leaders expect in updates,
Generational communication differences	Younger employees may be more used to fast, casual, chat-based communication
Fear of judgment	Interns may avoid asking questions because they do not want to
Lack of practice	Traditional onboarding often explains policies but does not provide communication rehearsal
Cognitive overload	Interns are learning systems, names, tasks, and culture at the same

The training should therefore reduce uncertainty and provide simple, repeatable communication structures.

8. Recommended Training Solution

Recommended Format

A **90-minute instructor-led workshop** should be included in the intern onboarding program.

The session should be interactive and scenario-based rather than lecture-heavy. It should include discussion, examples, message rewriting, role-play, and personal action planning.

Component	Recommendation
Delivery mode	Live in-person or virtual workshop
Duration	90 minutes
Audience size	15–25 interns
Facilitator	L&D facilitator, HR onboarding lead, or early talent specialist
Optional guest	Manager or senior leader for real-world perspective
Materials	Slide deck, facilitator guide, participant worksheet, communication checklist
Reinforcement	30-day action plan and manager check-in prompt

A blended approach is appropriate here: the workshop provides active practice, while job aids and follow-up prompts support transfer after training. Effective corporate training often combines workshops, on-the-job application, and microlearning reinforcement.

9. Proposed Learning Goal

By the end of the training, new interns will be able to adapt their communication style when interacting with senior managers and leaders by using clear structure, professional tone, active listening, and feedback-response strategies in common workplace situations.

10. Draft Learning Objectives

By the end of the session, learners will be able to:

Objective	Performance Focus
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Identify common communication expectations between interns and senior	Awareness
Differentiate between casual, professional, and leadership-facing communication styles	Judgment
Apply a simple structure for emails, chats, and verbal updates	Skill application
Demonstrate how to ask clear questions and clarify expectations	Practice
Respond to feedback using a professional and growth-oriented approach	Behavior
Create a personal 30-day communication action plan	Transfer

Learning objectives should be action-oriented and focus on what learners should be able to do after training, not only what they should know.

11. Proposed Content Scope

The training should focus on five practical content areas.

Module	Focus
Module 1: Communication Across	Understanding different communication expectations
Module 2: Communicating Up	How to communicate with managers and leaders clearly
Module 3: Professional Tone in Email and Chat	How to revise casual or unclear messages into professional communication
Module 4: Meetings and Questions	How to prepare, participate, ask questions, and summarize
Module 5: Feedback and Growth	How to receive, clarify, and act on feedback

The topic of generations should be handled carefully. The goal is not to label people by age group, but to help interns recognize that communication preferences may vary by role, experience, context, and urgency.

12. Instructional Approach

The training should use a practical, learner-centered approach supported by the following learning theories:

Theory	Application in This Training
Adult Learning Theory	Use relevant workplace examples that interns can apply immediately
Social Learning Theory	Show examples of weak and strong communication, then let learners
Constructivism	Let learners build understanding through scenarios, discussion, and

Cognitive Load Management	Use simple frameworks and short practice activities instead of too much theory
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Instructional design uses evidence-based theories such as constructivism, social learning theory, adult learning theory, and ADDIE to create structured learning experiences.

13. Sample Practice Scenarios

The following scenarios should be used during the Design and Development phases:

Scenario	Skill Practiced
Intern does not understand a task but feels nervous asking the manager	Asking clear questions
Intern sends a vague Teams message to a senior project lead	Professional chat tone
Intern receives corrective feedback on a report	Responding to feedback
Intern is invited to a meeting with directors	Meeting preparation and confidence
Intern notices a potential project delay	Escalating with context and
Intern needs to follow up after no response	Polite, professional follow-up

These scenarios will allow learners to practice communication in a safe environment before applying the skills on the job.

14. Stakeholders

Stakeholder	Role in the Project
L&D Team	Designs and facilitates the training
HR / Early Talent Team	Owens intern onboarding and program alignment
Intern Managers	Reinforce communication expectations after training
Senior Leaders	Sponsor the importance of professional communication
Interns	Primary learners and participants
SMEs	Provide realistic workplace examples and communication expectations

Stakeholder communication and collaboration are important instructional design competencies, especially when aligning training to real workplace needs.

15. Constraints and Assumptions

Area	Constraint / Assumption
Time	Intern onboarding is busy, so the session should stay within 90 minutes
Delivery	Training should work both in person and virtually
Learner readiness	Interns may feel nervous discussing communication mistakes openly
Psychological safety	Activities should be supportive, not judgmental
Content sensitivity	Generational differences should be framed carefully to avoid stereotypes
Assessment	Scenario-based assessment is more appropriate than a formal test
Transfer	Managers should reinforce the communication model after training

16. Evaluation Plan Preview

The full evaluation strategy will be developed later, but the Analysis phase identifies the following success measures.

Evaluation Level	Measurement Method
Reaction	Post-session survey on relevance, confidence, and usefulness
Learning	Scenario-based message rewrite and role-play performance
Behavior	Manager observation after 30–60 days
Results	Faster onboarding, fewer communication misunderstandings, stronger intern engagement

Evaluation should go beyond completion rates and focus on workplace behavior change and performance improvement.

17. Final Recommendation

It is recommended that NorthStar Rail proceed to the Design phase for a 90-minute onboarding workshop titled:

Communicating Up: Building Confidence Across Generations

The training should focus on practical communication skills for new graduate interns, including asking clear questions, adjusting tone, participating in meetings, communicating with senior

leaders, and responding to feedback. The workshop should use realistic scenarios, short communication frameworks, and guided practice to support behavior change.

This project is a strong fit for the intern onboarding program because it addresses a real early-career performance gap and supports both intern confidence and manager effectiveness.

Stakeholder Approval Needed Before Design Phase

Before moving to the Design phase, stakeholders should confirm:

Decision Area	Recommendation
Training audience	New graduate interns
Session length	90 minutes
Delivery mode	Instructor-led workshop, in person or virtual
Training focus	Communicating with managers and leaders across generational differences
Assessment style	Scenario-based practice and action planning
Reinforcement	Job aid plus 30-day manager check-in prompt